ETHIOPIAN ORTHODOX TEWAHEDO CHURCH

Pneumatology: The Doctrine of the Holy Spirit

WEEK-5



Pneumatological Heresies

- **Pneumatological heresies** are teachings that deviate from the orthodox understanding of the Holy Spirit most notably regarding the Spirit's divinity, personhood, or relationship to the Father and the Son.



- ✓ When looking at pneumatological "heresies" or errors through a strictly biblical lens, the focus shifts from the formal philosophical definitions of the later Church Councils to the specific behaviors and beliefs rebuked within the text itself.
- ✓ In the biblical narrative, these errors usually involve misinterpreting the Spirit's power, origin, or relationship to human authority.

"Unpardonable Sin"

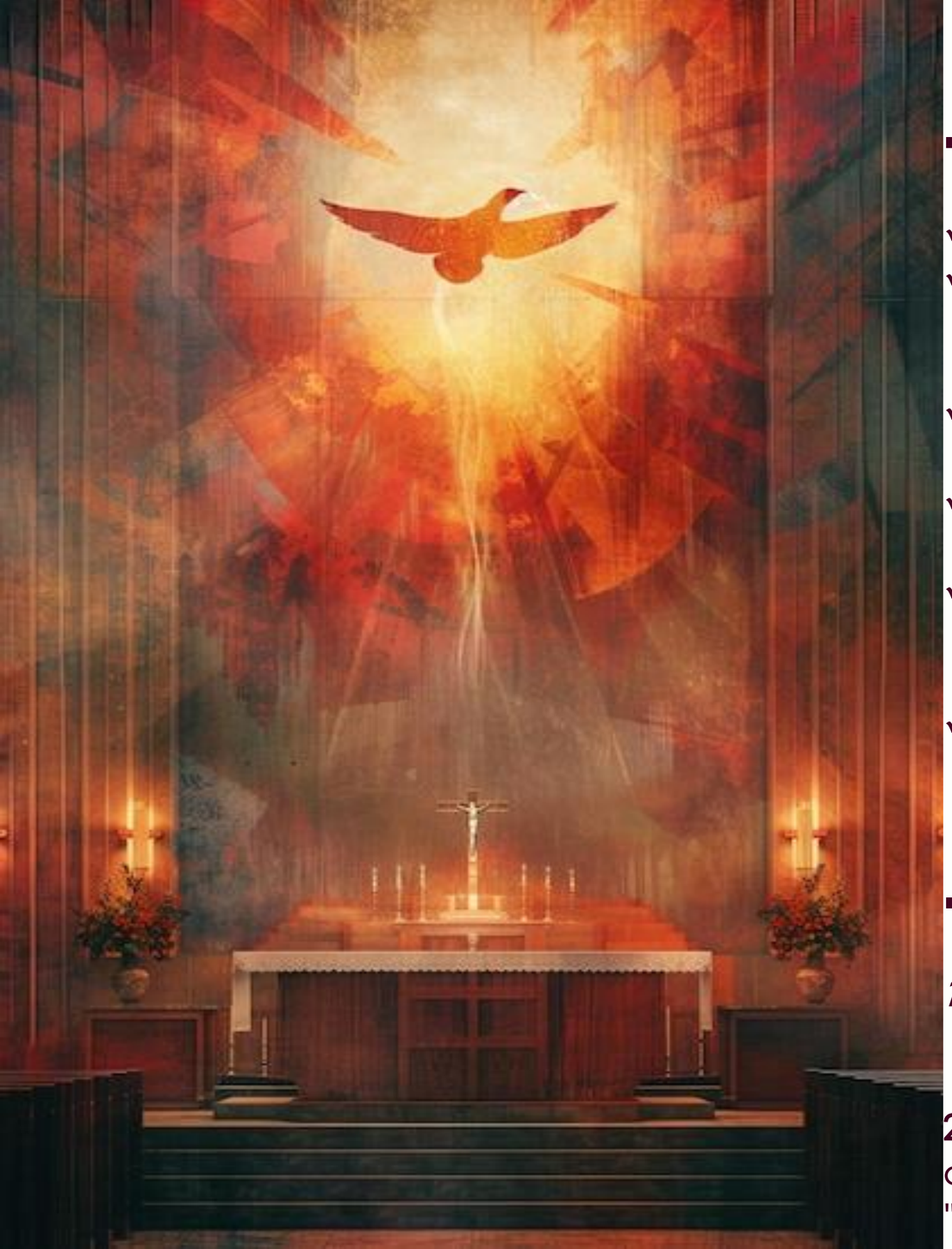
- ✓ "Blasphemy against the Holy Spirit" as the ultimate pneumatological error. In the biblical context, this isn't just a slip of the tongue, but a persistent, knowing rejection of the Spirit's testimony about Jesus Christ.

The Old Testament: Spirit vs. False Prophecy

In the Old Testament, "spirit" (ruach) is often tied to the "Spirit of Prophecy.

- " The primary errors involve claiming the Spirit’s authority for personal or political gain.
- The "Spirit of Lying": In 1 Kings 22, the prophet Micaiah describes a "lying spirit" in the mouths of Ahab’s prophets.
- The biblical warning here is against attributing to God messages that stem from human desire or deceptive spirits rather than the Ruach HaKodesh (Holy Spirit).
- Error of Eldad and Medad (Misunderstanding Scope): In Numbers 11, Joshua objects when two men prophesy outside the Tabernacle. Moses rebukes this narrow view, suggesting that the Spirit’s work is not a "limited resource" to be controlled by institutional gatekeepers.
- Assuming the Spirit is Permanent: 1 Samuel 16:14 shows the Spirit departing from Saul.
- A biblical "error" in the OT mindset was the assumption that the Spirit’s presence was a permanent right of office, rather than a gift of God’s favor.





The New Testament: Direct Rebukes

- New Testament contains specific accounts where individuals were corrected for their "pneumatological" misunderstandings.

✓ Simony (The Spirit as a Commodity)

✓ In Acts 8:9-24, Simon Magus witnesses the Spirit being given through the laying on of hands and offers the Apostles money to buy this power.

✓ The Heresy: Treating the Holy Spirit as a "technique" or a "commodity" that can be controlled or purchased.

✓ Peter's Rebuke: "May your money perish with you, because you thought you could buy the gift of God with money!".

✓ Blasphemy Against the Holy Spirit Mentioned in Matthew 12 and Mark 3, this occurs when the Pharisees attribute the miracles Jesus performed by the ***Spirit to Beelzebul*** (the devil).

✓ The Heresy: Attributing the ***Holy work of the Spirit to an unclean source***. This is described as a ***"terminal"*** hardness of heart because it rejects the very agent of repentance.

Grieving and Quenching the Spirit

- The Epistles warn against practical errors in how believers interact with the Spirit.

1. ***Quenching*** (1 Thessalonians 5:19): The error of suppressing or devaluing spiritual gifts and the Spirit's movement within the community.

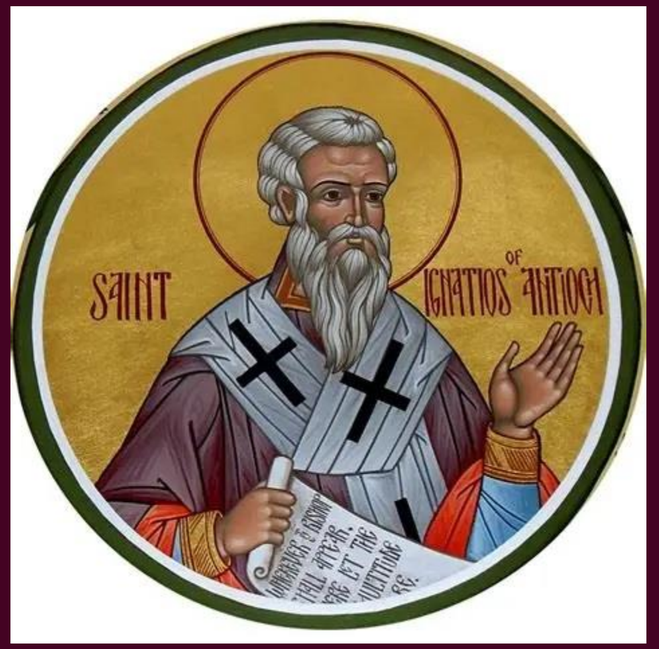
2. ***Grieving*** (Ephesians 4:30): Living in a way that is fundamentally opposed to the Spirit's nature (bitterness, anger, malice), causing a "break" in the relationship.

Early Church (roughly the 2nd through 4th centuries)

❖ The period of the Early Church (roughly the 2nd through 4th centuries) was the "crucible" for pneumatology.

✓ During this time, the Church moved from the raw, experiential descriptions of the Spirit found in the New Testament to the formal, philosophical definitions found in the Creeds. The heresies of this era generally fell into two camps: those who thought the

1. Spirit was too powerful/independent (Extra-biblical revelation)
2. Spirit was not divine enough (Subordinationism).



2nd Century: The Challenge of Authority

In the immediate post-apostolic age, the main concern was where the "voice" of the Spirit resided.

- Montanism (The New Prophecy): Montanus and two prophetesses (Priscilla and Maximilla) claimed the Holy Spirit was speaking through them to provide new commandments.

✓ *Conflict:* This forced the Early Church to decide if the "Age of Revelation" had closed with the Apostles.

✓ *Outcome:* The Church moved toward "Institutional Pneumatology," arguing that the Spirit works primarily through the established scriptures and the succession of bishops, rather than *"wild"* new prophecies.

Early Church (roughly the 2nd through 4th centuries)

3rd Century Challenge of Identity

As theologians began to use Greek philosophy to explain God, they *struggled to categorize the Spirit without falling into "Tritheism" (three gods).*

1. Modalistic Monarchianism (Sabellianism):To protect the "Oneness" (Monarchia) of God, Sabellius taught that the Father, Son, and Spirit were just names for different roles God played.

✓ Heresy: It suggested the Spirit was just God *"in action" on earth, rather than an eternal, distinct person.*

2. Subordinationism (Early Roots): Some early writers, in their attempt to show the Father as the *"Source," accidentally made the Spirit sound like a third-tier citizen of heaven* inferior to the Son, who was inferior to the Father.



Early Church (roughly the 2nd through 4th centuries)

4th Century "Spirit-Fighters"

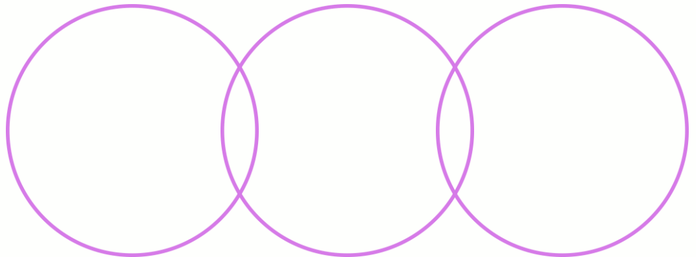


This was the most critical period. After the Council of Nicaea (325 AD) focused on the divinity of the Son, a group emerged that accepted the Son's divinity but balked at the Spirit's.

1. **Tropici:** A group in Egypt (combatted by Athanasius) who argued that the Spirit was "*created out of nothing*" and *was essentially an angel.*
2. **Pneumatomachianism (The Macedonians):** a Bishop Macedonius of Constantinople, they claimed the Spirit was a *"minister" or "servant"* of the Father and Son, but not "Homoousios" (of the same substance).

✓ **Defense:** "Cappadocian Fathers" (Basil the Great, Gregory of Nyssa, and Gregory of Nazianzus) argued that if the Spirit is not God, He cannot sanctify us or make us "partakers of the divine nature."

Event	Year	Result for Pneumatology
Condemnation of Montanism	~170s AD	Affirmed that the Spirit does not contradict Apostolic Scripture.
Letters to Serapion (Athanasius)	359 AD	First major theological defense of the Spirit's full divinity.
Basil the Great's On the Holy Spirit	375 AD	Proved that the Spirit is "ranked with" (not under) the Father and Son.
Council of Constantinople	381 AD	Formally added "And in the Holy Spirit, the Lord and Giver of Life..." to the Creed.



some of the heretical teachings about the Holy Spirit.

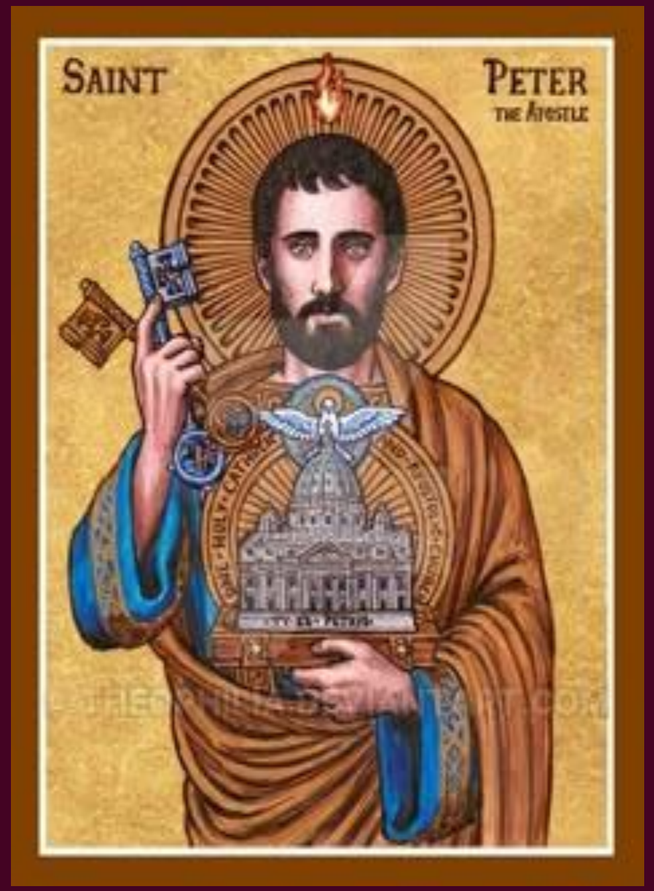
Simon Magus (Simon the Sorcerer)

a pivotal figure,he is often cited not only for a specific biblical error but as the *"Father of Heresies"* in the early patristic tradition.

- ✓ His story bridges the gap between the New Testament narrative and the complex philosophical heresies of the 2nd century.

1. The Biblical Account (Acts 8:9–24) Simon was a practitioner of magic in Samaria who had a large following and was called *"the Great Power of God."* After witnessing the miracles of Philip the Evangelist, Simon was baptized.

- ✓ Error: offered them money, saying, "Give me also this ability so that everyone on whom I lay my hands may receive the Holy Spirit.
- ✓ Rebuke: Peter's response was a fierce condemnation of Simon's heart, stating that God's gift cannot be purchased. Peter perceived that Simon was *"full of bitterness and captive to sin.*
- ✓ "Legacy (Simony): This event gave birth to the term Simony the ecclesiastical crime of buying or selling spiritual offices, preferences, or sacraments.



some of the heretical teachings about the Holy Spirit.

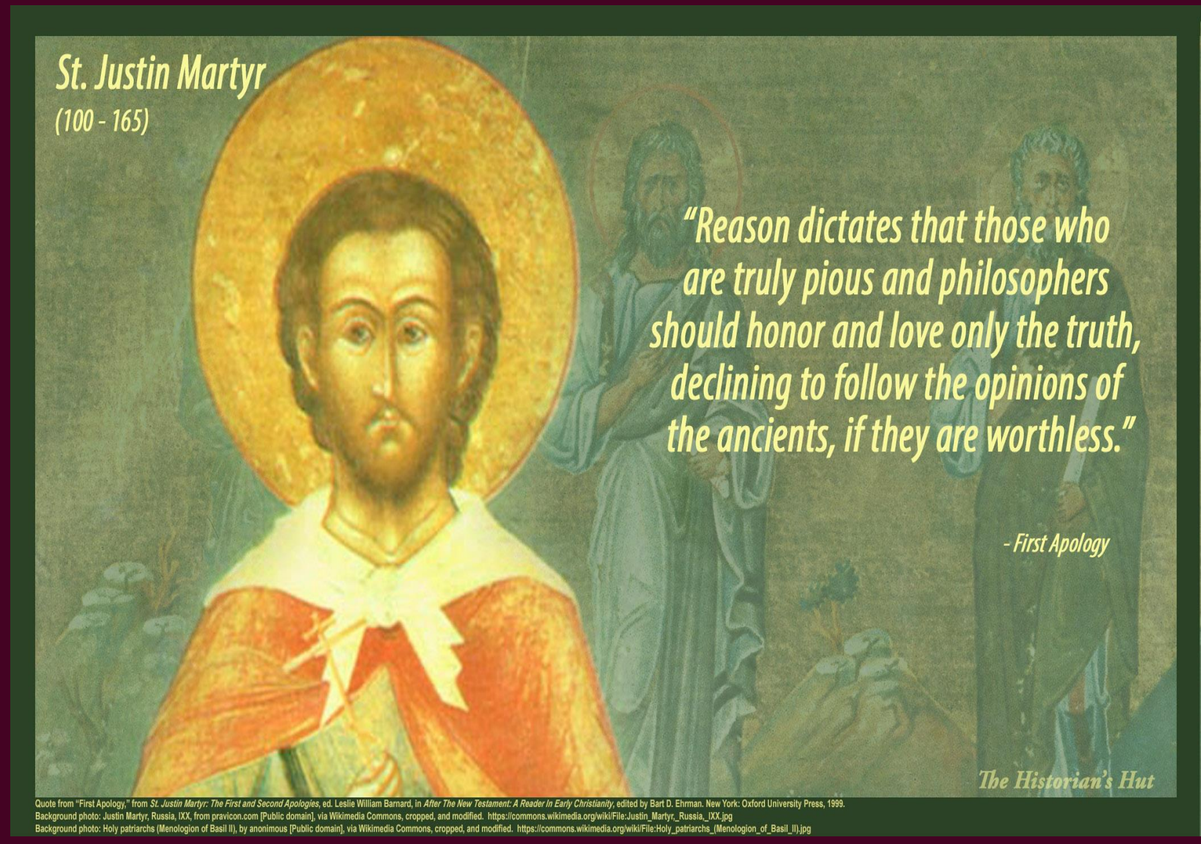
Simon Magus (Simon the Sorcerer)

2. The Early Church Tradition (The "Father of Heresy")Beyond the Book of Acts, early Christian writers (like *Irenaeus, Justin Martyr, and Hippolytus*) paint a much darker picture of Simon. They identify him as the founder of Gnosticism.

Pneumatological Deviation

In Gnostic systems attributed to Simon, the *"Spirit" or divine essence is* misunderstood in several ways:

- **"Great Power":** Simon claimed that he himself was a manifestation of God. He allegedly taught that God appeared as the Father to the Jews, as the Son to the Samaritans, and as the Holy Spirit to the Gentiles—all within his own person.
- **Ennoia (Helen):** Simon traveled with a woman named Helen, whom he claimed was the Ennoia (Divine Thought or Holy Spirit) fallen into the material world and trapped in a human body. He claimed he had descended to rescue her.



Quote from "First Apology," from *St. Justin Martyr: The First and Second Apologies*, ed. Leslie William Barnard, in *After The New Testament: A Reader In Early Christianity*, edited by Bart D. Ehrman. New York: Oxford University Press, 1999.
Background photo: Justin Martyr, Russia, IXX, from pravicon.com [Public domain], via Wikimedia Commons, cropped, and modified. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Justin_Martyr,_Russia,_IXX.jpg
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Feature	Biblical Simon (Acts)	Patristic Simon (Gnostic)
Primary Sin	Simony: Trying to buy the Spirit's power.	Self-Deification: Claiming to be the Spirit.
View of the Spirit	A tool/commodity for status.	An emanation/aeon to be "liberated."
Relationship to Church	Rebuked seeker/competitor.	The "Arch-Heretic" and rival to Peter.

Theological Significance for a student of theology, Simon Magus represents the first major collision between the Christian understanding of the Spirit and the Greco-Roman/Occult world:

- ✓ **Sovereignty of the Spirit:** Simon's story establishes that the Holy Spirit is a sovereign Person of the Trinity, not a "force" that can be manipulated by human technique or wealth.
- ✓ **Source of Grace**: It clarifies that the "laying on of hands" is a channel of God's grace, not a magical ritual that grants the minister personal power over the Divine.
- ✓ **"Pseudo-Spirit":** The later traditions about Simon serve as a warning against leaders who claim to have a unique or "new" manifestation of the Spirit that centers on their own personality rather than on Christ.

Some of the heretical teachings about the Holy Spirit.

Valentinus (c. 100–160 AD)

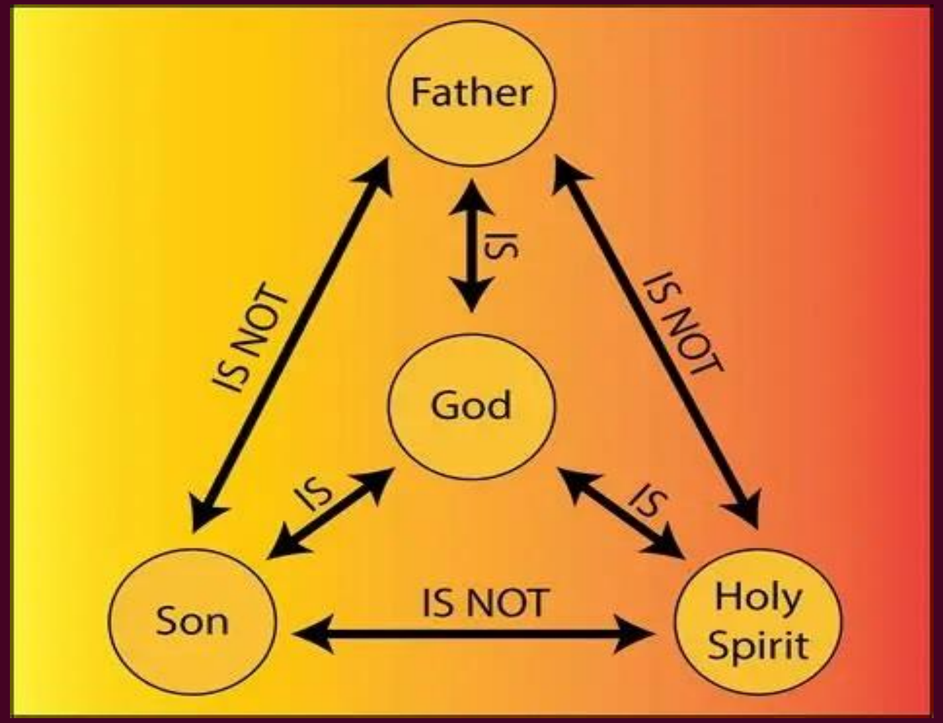
- Most influential and sophisticated of the early Gnostic theologians. A brilliant teacher who nearly became the Bishop of Rome, he developed a complex system that offered a radical and, to the early Church, heretical—reinterpretation of the Holy Spirit.

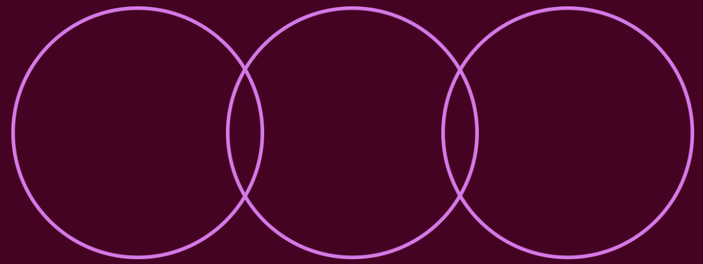
✓ In Valentinian Gnosticism, the *"Spirit"* is removed from the Trinity and placed into a cosmic hierarchy of Aeons (divine emanations).

1. The Valentinian Pleroma (The Fullness) : taught that the ultimate God (*the Bythos or Depth*) produced a series of paired emanations called *Aeons.* These 30 Aeons together make up the Pleroma.

Origin of the Spirit: In this system, the "Holy Spirit" and "Christ" are a pair of Aeons produced later in the process to restore order to the Pleroma after the fall of another Aeon, Sophia (Wisdom).

Departure from Orthodoxy: Instead of being co-eternal with the Father, the Spirit is a secondary creation designed for a specific functional task stabilizing the divine realm.





some of the heretical teachings about the Holy Spirit.

Valentinus (c. 100–160 AD)

2. Role of the Spirit: "Stabilizer"For Valentinus, the Holy Spirit had a very specific "pneumatological" job description

Healing the Fracture: When Sophia's desire caused chaos in the divine realm, the Spirit was produced to teach the other Aeons about their true nature and restore harmony.

"Cross" (Horos): The Spirit acts as a boundary (Horos) that separates the divine Pleroma from the deficient material world we live in. into the material world and trapped in a human body. He claimed he had descended to rescue her.

3. Three Classes of Humanity. Perhaps the most famous "heresy" of Valentinus regarding the Spirit was his division of humanity into three distinct natures. He believed the "Spirit" was not for everyone:

A. *Pneumatics (Spiritual):* Those who possess the "seed" of the Spirit. Only they are capable of true Gnosis (knowledge) and are destined for salvation regardless of their actions.
B. *Psychics (Soulish):* Ordinary Christians who have faith but lack deep Gnosis. They can be saved through good works and faith, but only to a secondary level of heaven.
C. *Hylics (Material):* Those who are purely physical and have no spark of the Spirit. They are destined for destruction.



Montanus(156–172 AD)

known in its own time as the **"New Prophecy,"** Phrygia (Turkey).

- ✓ it didn't necessarily deny the Spirit's divinity, but rather claimed *a new, ongoing revelation* that rivaled the authority of the Apostles.
- ✓ Founded by *Montanus* and two women, *Priscilla* and *Maximilla,* it created a massive stir across the Roman Empire, even attracting the famous North African theologian *Tertullian.*
- ❖ Core Pneumatological Claims : belief that the "Age of the Paraclete" (the Holy Spirit) had fully arrived through Montanus and his colleagues.
- ✓ *Ecstatic Prophecy:* Unlike the biblical prophets who often spoke "for" God (e.g., "Thus says the Lord"), Montanists practiced "passive" prophecy.
- ➢ They claimed the Spirit took complete control of their bodies, speaking as God in the first person. Montanus reportedly said:

  "I am the Lord God Almighty dwelling in man.
- ✓ "*The Completion of Revelation:* They believed the Spirit was giving new ethical commands and theological insights not found in the Gospels.
- ✓ *Imminent Eschatology:* A major focus of their "inspired" messages was the immediate return of Christ. They claimed the "New Jerusalem" would soon descend in Phrygia.



Montanus(156–172 AD)

2. Why the Church Labeled it a Heresy : While Montanists were doctrinally "orthodox" regarding the Trinity and the Resurrection, the Church Fathers (*like Eusebius and Epiphanius)* condemned them for three primary reasons:

A. *The Closure of the Canon :-* Montanism threatened the finality of the Apostolic witness.

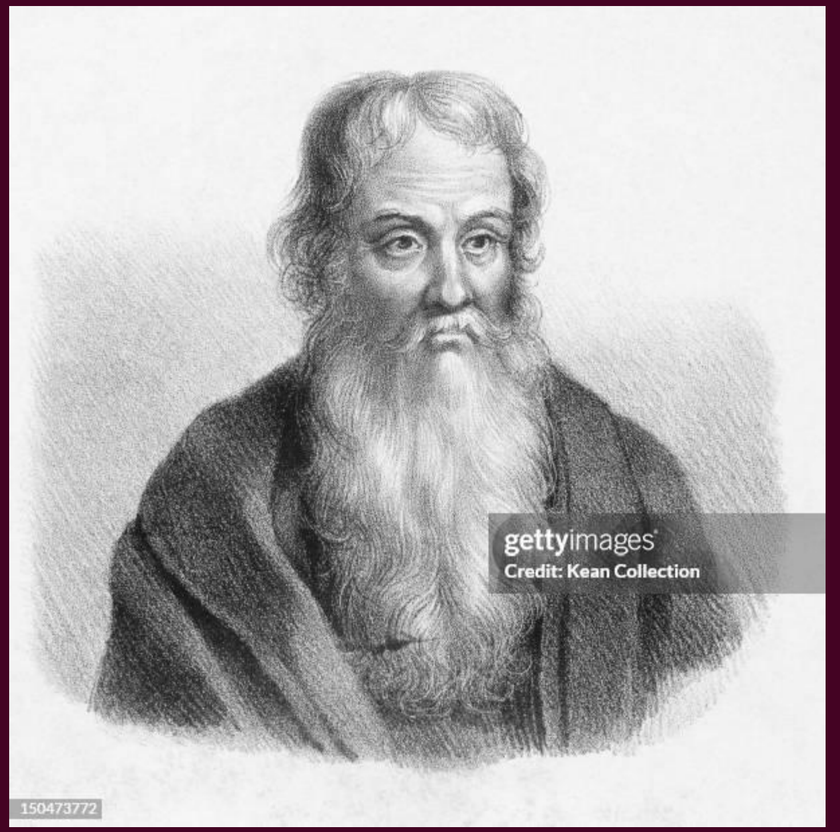
- Church began to argue that the Spirit's role was to remind and illuminate the teachings of Jesus, not to bypass them with new "updates."

B. The Nature of Inspiration :- Church criticized the *"frenzy" or "ecstasy"* of Montanist prophets.

- Orthodox writers argued that true prophets remain in control of their faculties (compos mentis), whereas the Montanists were seen as being possessed in a way that resembled pagan oracular cults.

C. Strict Legalism (Rigid Ethics):- "Spirit" in Montanism demanded extreme asceticism:

- Prohibition of second marriages (even for widows).
- Strict, frequent fasting.
- A ban on fleeing from persecution (seeking martyrdom).
- Refusal to forgive "mortal sins" committed after baptism.



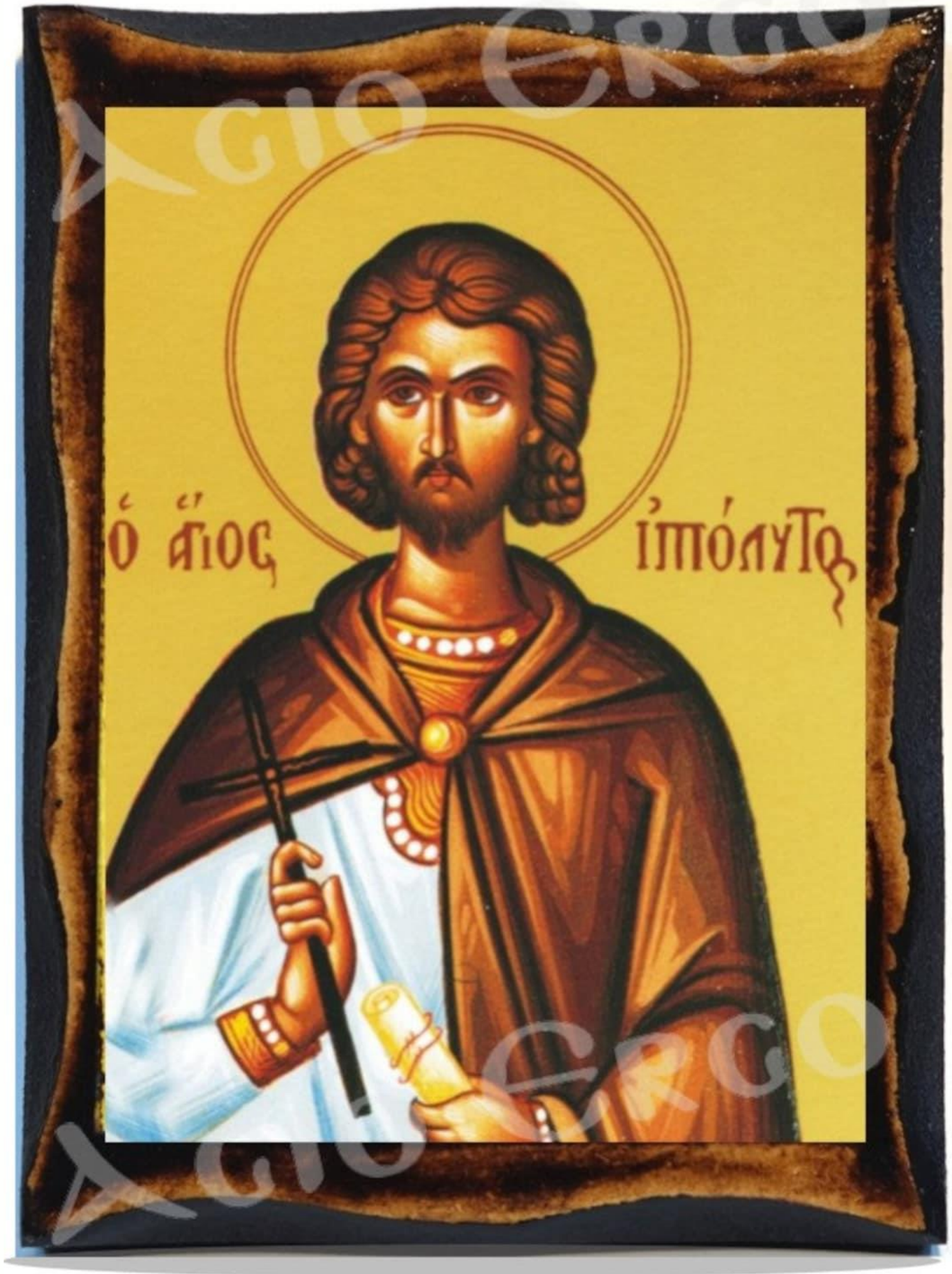
Monarchian (2nd-3rd)

Monarchianism emerged as a well-intentioned but theologically problematic attempt to protect the "Monarchy" (Monarchia) or the absolute oneness of God.

- ✓ As early Christians struggled to explain how Jesus and the Holy Spirit relate to the Father without falling into "polytheism," two distinct theories developed.
- ✓ Both significantly impacted Pneumatology by either denying the Spirit's distinct personhood or relegating the Spirit to a mere "power." to distinguish between spiritual gifts and the fruits of the Spirit;
- ➢ gifts are given for service,
- ➢ fruits reflect the character of a Spirit-filled life.

1. **Dynamic Monarchianism (Adoptionism):-** This theory focused primarily on Christology but had a "deflating" effect on the Holy Spirit.

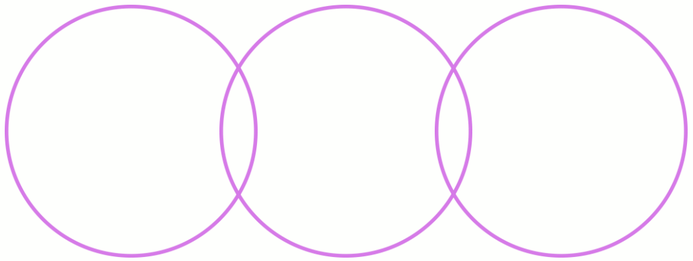
- ✓ *Core Theory:* Jesus was a mere human who was "adopted" by God. At his baptism, the "Christ" or "Divine Power" descended upon him.
- ✓ *Pneumatological Impact*: In this view, Holy Spirit is not a divine Person. Instead, "Holy Spirit" is simply another name for the impersonal power or influence of the Father.
- ✓ *Key Figure:* Theodotus of Byzantium and later Paul of Samosata. The Error: It denies *the being of the Spirit*, reducing the third person of the Trinity to a "*force" or "energy" used by God.*



2. Modalistic Monarchianism (Sabellianism):- more popular and dangerous version, often called Sabellianism after its most famous proponent, Sabellius.

- ✓ *Core Theory:* It taught that Father, Son, and Holy Spirit are not three distinct persons, but three modes or "masks" (prosopa) worn by the one God at different times.
- ➢ OT, God played the "mask" of the Father (Creator/Lawgiver).
- ➢ In the Gospels, He played the "mask" of the Son (Redeemer).
- ➢ In the Church age, He plays the "mask" of the Holy Spirit (Sanctifier).
- ✓ *Pneumatological Impact:* Holy Spirit is seen as the current "phase" of God's activity.
- ✓ *Error:* It denies the eternal relationship between the Persons. If the Spirit is just a "mode," then the Spirit cannot intercede to the Father (as seen in Romans 8:26), because the Spirit and the Father are the exact same person.
- ❖ Orthodox Response: Tertullian was the first to dismantle these theories effectively. He coined the formula that became the standard for the Church: *"One Substance, Three Persons"*
- ✓ argued that the "Monarchy" of God is not compromised by having a "Divine Economy" (an internal organization). He used analogies to explain the Spirit's distinct but inseparable nature:
- ✓ The Root, the Shoot, and the Fruit: The Father is the root, the Son is the shoot, and the Spirit is the fruit.
- ✓ The Fountain, the River, and the Stream: The Spirit is the "stream" that flows from the Father through the Son.





Arianism(c. 250–336 AD)

Primarily famous for its denial of the full divinity of Jesus Christ, it carries a necessary and equally radical "heresy" regarding the Holy Spirit.



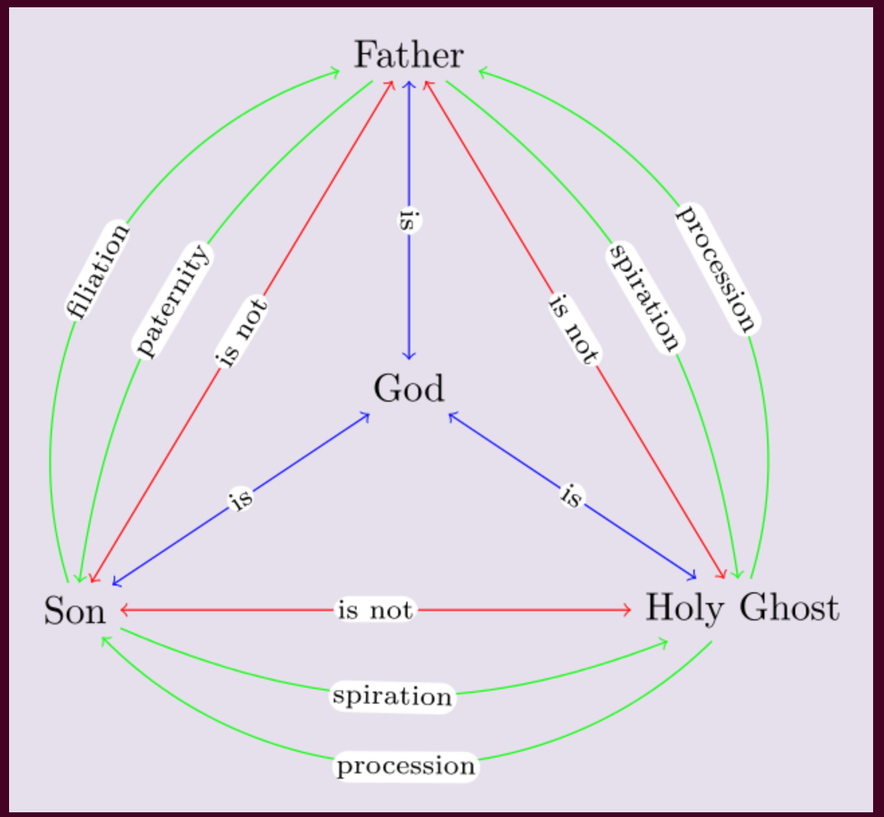
1. Arian Hierarchy of Being

- ✓ *Son:* Created by the Father as the first and greatest of all creatures.
- ✓ *Holy Spirit:* Created by the Son (at the Father's command).
- ✓ *Result:* The Spirit is essentially a "grandchild" of the Father in terms of derivation. This makes the Spirit a creature of a creature.
- ✓ *Errors*:- Regarding the Spirit Arianism rejected the Orthodox view of the Spirit on three specific fronts:
- ➢ *Denial of Homoousios (Same Substance):* Arians argued the Spirit did not share the same essence as the Father. They viewed the Spirit as having a completely different nature (heteroousios).
- ➢ *The Spirit as an "Instrument":* Spirit was viewed not as a Sovereign Person, but as a "ministering spirit" or a high-ranking angelic force used by the Son to influence the world.
- ➢ *Temporal Beginning:* Arius famously said of the Son, *"There was a time when he was not."* By extension, Arianism taught *there was a time when the Holy Spirit did not exist,* as He was brought into being only after the Son.
  - ➢ *sub-sect emerged known as the Pneumatomachoi (Spirit-Fighters) or Macedonians.*
  - ➢ *(Basil the Great, Gregory of Nazianzus, and Gregory of Nyssa) realized that Arianism made salvation impossible. Their argument was simple: "If the Spirit is not God, He cannot make us like God." Basil the Great*

"Filioque" Controversy

The Division Between Eastern Orthodox and Roman Catholic Churches on the Procession of the Holy Spirit

- ✓ *Filioque, (and the Son), the procession of the Holy Spirit* from the Father and the Son, is a theological expression which the Eastern Orthodox Church contested and emphasized that it is a Western Latin Church theology
- Meanwhile, the Easter Orthodox Church affirms that the Spirit proceeds from the Father alone through the Son.
- ❑ East argues that saying the Spirit proceeds from both the Father and the Son undermines the Father as the *sole source of the Trinity*.



Heresy on the Divinity of the Holy Spirit "Apollinarius"

- ✓ *Pneumatomachi* , Macedonians or Semi-Arians were a heresies who emerged in Constantinople and the Tropici of Alexandria, were an anti Nicene Creed sect appeared during the latter half of the fourth, and the beginning of the fifth centuries.
- ❖ denied the *Godhood of the Holy Ghost* hence the Greek name Pneumatomachi or 'Combaters against the Spirit' (from πνεῦμα *pneuma*, spirit + μάχη *machē*, battle)

- **Binitarianism**:- While not exclusively a pneumatological heresy, it directly impacts the doctrine of the Spirit. The Claim:
- ✓ Binitarians believe in the divinity of the Father and the Son but do not recognize the Holy Spirit as a distinct, divine Person.
- ✓ *The Issue:* The Spirit is often relegated to a "force," "power," or an "attribute" of God rather than a co-equal member of the Trinity.



Speaking in Tongues

Speaking in tongues (Gr. Glossologia) is a gift of the Holy Spirit by which the ability to speak a foreign language without having to be taught it or knowing it beforehand is granted to the person.

Disproving the Current Exercise of practicing of Glossologia :

1. The true gift of speaking in tongues is when someone speaks a language that is understood by those who hear him as mentioned in (Acts 2:1-13).
2. When someone speaks a language among people who do not understand it, then another gift, the gift of translation of this language into the language of the people, is necessary. Without this translation, the foreign language is considered babbling.

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Discussion & Reflection

How can we encounter the Holy Spirit in the current time?